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Prayer and Fasting

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Prayer and Fasting

Fasting is an important spiritual discipline that helps deepen one's walk with God.

Moses, King David, and prophets in the Old Testament fasted to come before the LORD.

"So he was there with the Lord forty days and forty nights; he did not eat bread, and he did not drink water. He wrote on the tablets the words of the covenant, the Ten Commandments." (Exodus 34:28)

"When I heard these things I sat down abruptly, crying and mourning for several days. I continued fasting and praying before the God of heaven." (2 Samuel 12:16)

"When I heard these things I sat down abruptly, crying and mourning for several days. I continued fasting and praying before the God of heaven." (Nehemiah 1:4)

In the New Testament, Jesus taught about fasting:

"When you fast, do not look sullen like the hypocrites, for they make their faces unattractive so that people will see them fasting. I tell you the truth, they have their reward! When you fast, anoint your head and wash your face, so that it will not be obvious to others when you are fasting, but only to your Father who is in secret. And your Father, who sees in secret, will reward you." (Matthew 6:16-18)

Although prayer is commanded by God (e.g. 1 Thessalonians 5:17; 1 Timothy 2:8), fasting is not. However, fasting is very powerful if approached with the right heart attitude. It is a tool to grow closer to God as you earnestly seek to know and follow His heart, mind, and will.

How to Fast

Even when you have some urgent needs to seek God, going into prolonged fasting without proper preparation is unwise and even dangerous. For example, when King David was fasting for his dying child, he was attended by his servants who were looking after his wellbeing. It is also important to remember that some individuals, such as diabetics, may have health conditions that prevent them from fasting. Before fasting, it is recommended to consult medical professionals and/or Christian leaders experienced with fasting.

Small Steps

It is best to focus on developing a habit and start “small”.

Because God does not command us to fast, there is no single correct way to fast. Among those who regularly fast and pray:

- Some fast one day a week or one day every three months.
- Some fast for three days at the beginning of each month.
- Some have used the “Daniel Fast” (Daniel 1:8–14).
- Some have undertaken forty-day fasts.

To start, consider skipping one regular meal. Instead of eating, spend that time in prayer and/or reading the Word. You can do this occasionally or choose to make this a weekly habit.

Next, try skipping two consecutive meals, such as breakfast and lunch, lunch and dinner, or dinner and breakfast the next morning. During these times, it is crucial to drink water to stay hydrated. This practice can also be incorporated into regular spiritual discipline routines.

Your fasting experience will differ from others because each body is unique. Typically, the first three days are the most challenging, with acute hunger, irritation, weakness, or difficulty concentrating. After three days, hunger may decrease, but the body undergoes significant changes. If planning to fast longer than three days, seek guidance from someone knowledgeable about fasting.

Fasting is powerful, but you may not always see the result you expect. Similar to prayer, the primary purpose of fasting is to be in God’s presence. By learning to delight in His presence through fasting, you can trust that God will respond perfectly in His timing with His perfect answer.